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Newsom signs bills to boost housing, provide more hotel shelter beds

August 29, 2024 | Arcadia Weekly, The (CA)
Author: Staff | Section: News | 742 Words
Page: 1
OpenURL Link

Gov. Gavin Newsom on Tuesday signed two bills to address homelessness that aim to help local governments add more shelter beds and facilitate the swifter construction of housing units.

Assembly Bill 2835 eliminates the sunset date on tenancy rules that make it easier for service providers to place people experiencing homelessness into privately owned hotels and motels for more than 30 days. This approach has been proven to enhance stability for those in need.

AB 3057 aims to streamline and "jumpstart" local governments' procedures for issuing building permits for "junior accessory dwelling units," or JADUs, in an effort to create more affordable rental units statewide. An example of a junior accessory dwelling unit is the conversion of a singlefamily home's garage into a living space.

"The homelessness crisis demands immediate and innovative action, not the status quo," Newsom said in a statement. "With these new laws, local governments have even more tools to provide housing. I urge them to fully utilize the state's unprecedented resources to address homelessness."

Local governments and service providers from private industry and the nonprofit sector throughout the state have successfully used hotels and motels to provide housing for people experiencing homelessness.

The governor's office noted that since 2019 when Newsom took office, the state has invested more than $27 billion to support local governments in providing services and housing to help prevent and end homelessness. Notable spending included $3.3 billion for the Homekey program, $1 billion in Encampment Resolution Funding and $4.85 billion in funding for the Homelessness Housing Assistance Program, offi-cials said.

Last year approximately 181, 000 people experienced homelessness in California, with approximately 90, 000 living in unsheltered scenarios, Newsom's office reported. The state funding aims to help local communities address unsheltered homelessness by utilizing rooms in hotels and motels to augment available shelter space.

"This strategy not only creates additional safe and stable interim shelter for Californians experiencing homelessness but also helps ensure that service providers can more easily connect and support people with the services they need to access housing and exit homelessness permanently," according to the statement from Newsom's office.

AB 2835 makes the use of motel and hotels to supplement shelter beds an indefinite option for local governments.

"We need solutions to our homelessness crisis that are both compassionate and effective," said Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, the bill's author. "AB 2835 will deliver on both fronts by providing much-needed stability to kids and families experiencing homelessness while also cutting red tape and saving taxpayer resources."

In an effort to increase the number of rental units statewide to bring rent costs down, AB 3057 focuses on junior accessory dwelling units, which are units created within existing homes. JADUs can be up to 500 square feet and do not require a separate bathroom. These smaller units will now be exempt from the California Environmental Quality Act requirements, which can delay a project's completion and increase costs.

Officials said among the many factors that cause a person to lose access to housing, the lack of available affordable residential units in the state is a key driver. Most people who become homeless cite economic hardship such as increased rent or housing costs.

State officials see accessory dwelling units and JADUs as "innovative and effective options" for adding units to make housing in California more affordable.

"AB 3057 represents a small but significant technical change that offers Californians more accessible and efficient options to build affordable housing solutions," said Assemblywoman Lori D. Wilson, the bill's author. "This bill makes it faster, cheaper, and easier for families to create additional living spaces within their homes, helping to address our state's housing shortage. This legislation allows families to stay closer together and fosters stronger, more connected communities. I am grateful to Governor Newsom for signing this bill and to California YIMBY for their unwavering commitment to making California an affordable place for everyone." Since 2019 the state has spent over $40 billion to encourage affordable housing and over $27 billion for efforts to reduce homelessness. The 2024 census of people experiencing homelessness conducted in late January estimated that 75, 312 in Los Angeles County, and 45, 252 in the city of LA, which were slight reductions after increases reported over the last several years.

Last year California's estimated unhoused population was more than 181, 000, according to the U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development.

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Staff. (2024, August 29). Newsom signs bills to boost housing, provide more hotel shelter beds*Arcadia Weekly, The (CA)*, p. 1. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/19CD6C3CC3339480.